

Session 24: The Symmetry of the Ship Scene

Key Takeaways

- Chiasms encourage us to compare and contrast parallel sections of the text.
- Jonah's actions and words are often in contrast, and this is intentional. The author wants us to draw our own conclusions and continue questioning Jonah's motives.

Jonah, the Storm, and the Sailors: Translation and Literary Design of Jonah 1:4-16

A

4 Now, Yahweh had **hurled** a great wind **to the sea** and there was a great storm on the sea, and the ship considered breaking apart.

5 And the sailors **feared** and each cried to his god, and they **hurled** the cargo which was in the ship **to the sea** to make it lighter from upon them. Now, Jonah **went down** into the far reaches of the ship, and he laid **down** and **fell asleep**.

B

6 And the chief of the sailors approached him and said, "What is it with you, **sleeping**? Get up, **call to your god**. Perhaps a god will be concerned about us **so that we will not perish**."

7 And each man said to his companion, "Come, let us cast lots, so that we can know **on whose account this evil is to us**." So they cast lots and the lot fell on Jonah.

C

8 **And they said to him**, "Please tell us, **on whose account is this evil to us**? What is your work? And where do you come from? What is your country? From what people are you?"

9 **And he said to them**, "I am a Hebrew, and I fear Yahweh God of heaven who made the sea and the dry land."

10 And the men **feared a great fear** and they said to him, "What is this you have done?!"

D For the men knew that he was fleeing **from before the face of Yahweh** because he had told them.

C' 11 **And they said to him**, "What should we do to you that the sea may become calm for us?" for the sea was going and storming.
12 **And he said to them**, "Pick me up and **hurl me to the sea** .
Then the sea will become calm for you,
for I know that **on account of me this great storm is to you.** "

B' 13 And the men dug in to return to land
but they could not, for the sea was going and storming against them.
14 And **they called to Yahweh** and said,
"Please Yahweh, **do not let us perish** on account of this man's life
and don't set innocent blood against us;
for you, O Lord, have done as you have pleased."

A' 15 And they picked up Jonah, and they **hurled him to the sea** ,
and the sea stopped its raging.
16 Then the men **feared** the Lord a **great fear** ,
and they offered sacrifices to Yahweh and **they vowed vows** .

Jonah 1:4-16. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).

Reflection Question

So far in chapter 1, what evidence of Jonah's motives being positive do you see? What evidence of Jonah's motives being negative do you see? Why do you think the author decides not to tell us what Jonah's motives are?